

Step 6: Add approval points

“First show me two possible routes. After I choose one, create the detailed itinerary.”

Step 7: Add final format

“Give a day-wise table, estimated budget, packing checklist and three common mistakes to avoid.”

Now the agent has a real brief.

Prompting for research agents

Research agents are powerful because they can gather, compare and structure information. But they are also prone to overconfidence. A research prompt must insist on source discipline.

Use this template:

“Act as a research assistant. Research [topic] for [audience/purpose]. Use recent and credible sources. Separate confirmed facts from analysis. Provide citations or source names for important claims. Do not use outdated information if newer information exists. End with open questions or areas where evidence is weak.”

For example:

“Research the use of AI tutors in Indian schools for a technology magazine cover story. Focus on benefits, risks, classroom adoption, teacher workflows, language support and cheating concerns. Separate Indian examples from global examples. Give 10 article angles and 8 interview questions.”

A strong research agent should not merely dump information. It should structure the landscape.

Prompting for productivity agents

Productivity agents work best when you give them context and tone. For emails, always mention the relationship, purpose and desired tone.

Weak prompt:

“Reply to this email.”

Strong prompt:

“Draft a polite but firm reply to this vendor. We are interested, but the quoted price is 18 percent higher than expected. Ask for a revised quote, delivery timeline and warranty details. Keep it under 150 words. Do not commit to purchase.”

For meetings, try this:

“Turn this meeting transcript into minutes. Create four sections: decisions made, action items with owners, unresolved questions, and follow-up email draft. If an owner is unclear, mark it as ‘to be assigned’ instead of guessing.”

For weekly updates:

“Use these notes to create a Friday status update for my manager. Keep it concise, professional and specific. Include completed work, current blockers, next week’s priorities and decisions needed.”

ANATOMY OF AN AGENT-READY PROMPT

A strong agent prompt usually has seven parts.

- First, define the role. Do you want the agent to act like a research assistant, travel planner, spreadsheet analyst, coding helper, interview producer, teacher or customer support assistant?
- Second, define the goal. Say what needs to be achieved, not just what topic you are interested in.
- Third, provide context. Mention audience, location, budget, language, deadline, file names, constraints and background.
- Fourth, define tools. Can the agent browse the web? Use uploaded files? Analyse spreadsheets? Read emails? Work from notes only?
- Fifth, define boundaries. What should it avoid? What requires approval? What is out of scope?
- Sixth, define output format. Do not leave this to chance. Ask for sections, tables, bullets, word count, tone, examples or step-by-step instructions.
- Seventh, define quality checks. Ask for source links, assumptions, risks, missing information or a final verification pass.

Prompting for spreadsheet and data agents

Spreadsheet agents need precision. Do not simply say, “Analyse this data.” Tell the agent what to inspect.

A good prompt may say:

“Analyse this sales spreadsheet for April to June. Find top 10 products by revenue, bottom 10 by growth, unusual spikes, missing values and regional differences. Create a summary table and suggest three follow-up questions. Do not change the original file. Work on a copy.”

For Indian small businesses, this can be extremely useful. A local retailer can analyse monthly sales. A coaching centre can track student enquiries. A freelancer can review invoice delays. A housing society can categorise expenses.

Always include one line: “Do not overwrite the original file.” Data mistakes are easier to catch when the original remains untouched.

Prompting for creative agents

Creative prompts need direction, not just enthusiasm. “Make it catchy” is not enough. Define audience, platform, tone, length and examples.